What changed was how ACME Corp thought about authorization. Instead of hardcoding access logic or tying it rigidly to static roles, they started writing policies—declarative rules that outlined who should be allowed to do what under specific conditions. These policies became the main layer connecting employee, customer, and contractor data with resource metadata and organizational context.

In some systems, policies were defined in code, using attribute-based rules that considered roles, departments, clearance levels, and request context—an approach often associated with ABAC. In others, policies worked with data stored in a relationship graph—granting or denying access based on connections between people and resources. This data-centric approach, often implemented using ReBAC, enabled flexible delegation, collaboration, and real-time access checks that reflected how the business actually worked.

Together, these approaches merged into a larger shift: a transition to policy-based access control (PBAC). Whether implemented in code or driven by live relationship data, policies provided ACME with a single, consistent, yet dynamic way to express and enforce authorization logic across their expanding ecosystem.

6.1 Relationship-based access control

In traditional access control models, such as ACLs and RBAC, access decisions are typically based on static lists or assigned roles. But in collaborative, multi-tenant environments—like shared documents, issue tracking platforms, and customer portals—access often depends on relationships between people and resources. That’s where Relationship-Based Access Control (ReBAC) shines.

ReBAC grants permissions based on relationships between entities. Rather than ask, “Does this role grant permission?” ReBAC systems ask, “Does principal A have relation B to resource C?” These relationships could include owner, viewer, manager, or more complex indirect connections, such as “manager of the owner.” This model is particularly well-suited for systems where access is dependent on social, organizational, or collaborative structures.